THURSDAY PSALM · 12 NOVEMBER 2026 · 2 KISLEV 5787

Hear, My People

Psalm 81, the Thursday psalm, and the father who could only hear

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שְׁמַע עַמִּי וְאָעִידָה בָּךְ

“Hear, My people, and I will admonish you” (Psalms 81:9)

Aryeh Leib Thorne Toren — Torah scholar, researcher and writer

Hear, My People

Psalm 81, the Thursday psalm, and the father who could only hear

Aryeh Leib Thorne Toren

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Not for sale. For study at the table, in the beis midrash and at home.

Prepared in deep partnership and cooperation with Grok and xAI

Every Thursday the Levites in the Temple sang one psalm. The Mishnah lists the week day by day, and on the fifth day they sang Psalm 81, "For the leader; on the gittith. Of Asaph" (Mishnah Tamid 7:4). We still say it in shul every Thursday as the Shir shel Yom. On Thursday, 12 November 2026, it falls in the week of Toldot, and the two texts meet on one sense: hearing.

A father who could only hear

Yitzchak's eyes were too dim to see. Everything in the tent comes to him through the other senses. He touches. He smells. Above all he listens, and what he hears does not match what he feels: "The voice is the voice of Jacob, yet the hands are the hands of Esau" (Bereishit 27:22). The companion piece, *The Garments of Esav, the Voice of Yaakov*, follows the garments and the fragrance. Here I stay with the ear.

A man who cannot see must decide by what he hears. That is not only Yitzchak's situation. It is ours most of the week. We do not see G-d. We are asked to hear.

A language I did not know

Psalm 81 sets the decree of the new moon and the feast "upon Joseph when he went forth from the land of Egypt," and then says something strange: "I heard a language that I knew not" (Psalms 81:6).

עֵדוּת ו בְּהֹוסָף שָׂמוֹ בֶּצֱאתוֹ עַל־אֶרֶץ מִצְרָיִם שְׂפַת לֹא־יָדַעְתִּי אֶשְׁמָע

Yosef in Egypt, and Israel leaving it, hear speech they did not yet understand. Yitzchak in the tent hears a voice he cannot place. In both cases the listener has to keep listening past what he already knows. Hearing in the Torah is rarely easy. It is work.

Hear, My people

Then the psalm turns from history to us: "Hear, My people, and I will admonish you; Israel, if you would but listen to Me!" (Psalms 81:9).

שְׁמַע עַמִּ י וְאָעִידָה בָּךְ יִשְׂרָאֵל אִם־תִּשְׁמַע־לִי

Two verses later comes the promise: "open your mouth wide and I will fill it" (Psalms 81:11). The ear comes first, then the mouth. Yaakov's voice in the tent was a voice that asked. Psalm 81 says the voice we raise is meant to answer a voice we first heard.

On the site there is already a piece built on 81:14, *If Only My People Would Listen*. This one asks a narrower question. Not whether we listen, but how a person who cannot see learns to trust what he hears. Yitzchak had to. So do we.

The finest wheat

The psalm closes with food: "He fed them the finest wheat; I sated you with honey from the rock" (Psalms 81:17). Yitzchak's blessing that follows the tent is also about food, the dew of heaven and the fat of the earth. A blessing begins with hearing and ends at the table.

Toward Vayetze

After Shabbat, Yaakov leaves Beersheba with his father's words in his ears and walks into the dark toward Haran. In Vayetze he will sleep on the road and hear again. Thursday's psalm is a good place to start listening for that.

Sources

English verses from *Tanakh: The Holy Scriptures* (Jewish Publication Society, 1985), via Sefaria, opened 12 November 2026, with divine names written G-d and L-rd. Hebrew from the Sefaria Miqra text, vowels removed.

- Mishnah Tamid 7:4 (the Levites' daily psalms; Psalm 81 on the fifth day): https://www.sefaria.org/Mishnah_Tamid.7.4
- Psalms 81:6, 81:9, 81:11, 81:17: https://www.sefaria.org/Psalms.81
- Bereishit 27:22: https://www.sefaria.org/Genesis.27.22
- Companion: *The Garments of Esav, the Voice of Yaakov* (12 November 2026)
- Earlier piece on 81:14: *If Only My People Would Listen*, https://aryehleibtoren.com/writing/if-only-my-people-would-listen.html
- Forthcoming companion: a piece on Psalm 13

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All glory to the Ribono shel Olam · Errors are mine

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